

BEST BUY
digit
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Seagate
Pushbutton Backup 160 GB

the Freecom FHD-3 (400 GB) and the LaCie Design by F. A. Porsche 250 GB.

Features Capacities And RPM

We've mentioned the capacities of these drives above. All the drives in this category were 7200 rpm drives. All had a good 8 MB buffer, so data transfer is smooth.

Interfaces

The LaCie 250 GB drive features only USB 2.0. All the other drives feature the USB 2.0 as well as the FireWire interfaces. They come with two FireWire ports, a feature that lets you connect more drives in a daisy-chain, and that does not require the computer to have more FireWire ports to add compatible devices. This can be used to either connect other FireWire devices such as DV cams, or to augment the drive space by connecting more such drives.

Bundled Software

A backup button is present on all the drives except for the LaCie, whose software does not support such a feature. The Freecom FHD-3 comes bundled with the Freecom Personal Media Suite, which lets you back up or synchronise your data with the FHD-3 at the press of the button on the drive. Acronis True Image, a very good data backup and restore software, is also bundled with this drive.

The LaCie Design by F. A. Porsche 250 GB comes with the 1-Click data backup software as well as MacDrive, a software that allows you to connect and use Macintosh-formatted media directly on a PC. So if you connect this drive to a Windows PC, you can use the software to use the Mac-formatted drive with Windows without the need to reformat it to a Windows-compatible file system such as NTFS.

The Seagate drives are all bundled with the same data backup software—Bounceback Express, which in conjunction with the push-button on the drive, easily and conveniently backs up data.

Cables And Accessories

All the drives come with the requisite data cables and power adapters. Freecom bundles three power cables with different types of plugs for compatibility with different power plug-point types.

The LaCie comes with two power cables with plugs of different types. Except for the Freecom, all the drives have a power On/Off button, which lets you turn the drive on or off from the drive unit itself.

Other Features

The Freecom FHD-3 is the best-looking drive in this segment with its smooth finish and metallic lustre. It also has the best build quality, edging past the others. Next are the three Seagate drives, which are identical in looks and design. Last is the LaCie with its boxy design. Though it's called "Design by F. A. Porsche", we didn't find anything noteworthy about the design.

The Freecom and the Seagate drives have a design that facilitates stacking similarly-

All About USB And FireWire

USB is now ubiquitous—it is perhaps the first true plug 'n' play medium that PCs have. As much as it is widely used today, it was not taken seriously when it was first introduced in 1995—that was USB 1.0.

It was when the iMac was introduced in 1998, with only USB ports, that USB became popular. At about the same time, USB 1.1 came into the picture on Intel-based PCs along with support in Windows 98 (the first Windows version to natively support USB). It could work at two speeds—1.5 Mbps for devices such as mice and joysticks, and 12 Mbps (called high-speed) for devices such as disk drives. USB 2.0, which was introduced in 2000, supports a maximum of 480 Mbps. Nearly all USB devices and motherboards today support the USB 2.0 specification.

Some older motherboards, however, supported only legacy USB devices (keyboards and mice). You cannot plug your Webcam or external hard disk into these USB ports! In such a case, an inexpensive USB hub can be installed in a PCI slot.

Apple introduced the FireWire port in 1995. The FireWire interface is officially called IEEE 1394. FireWire connectivity is found more commonly on digital video cameras than USB is, though the speeds are comparable—FireWire supports a maximum of 400 Mbps. However, a recent improvement to the FireWire interface called FireWire II (officially IEEE 1394b) boosts the speed to 800 Mbps.

All PCs less than three years old have at least two USB 2.0 ports. However, a USB 2.0 device will work on a USB 1.1 port; it will just be slower. Unfortunately for FireWire, not many motherboards have been supporting it. It is only now that it is becoming a standard port.

A significant advantage FireWire has over USB is in the amount of power it can deliver—1.25 A at 12V gives 15 W, while USB's 500 mA at 5V gives 2.5 W. This means peripherals have more power at their disposal with FireWire.

Both the FireWire and USB interfaces support the use of a hub—meaning that with just one physical connection to the motherboard, many more devices can be connected, so long as the total current drawn does not exceed the amount supplied.

FireWire is used by devices such as external hard drives, external DVD-Writers, DV camcorders, high-end digital audio equipment, digital still cameras, printers, scanners, as well as home entertainment equipment such as personal video recorders, game consoles, home stereo equipment, DVD players, and digital TVs.

One of the reasons for the overwhelming popularity of USB is that motherboard manufacturers provide USB 2.0 ports on every motherboard these days. FireWire ports are not so commonly seen on motherboards.